Among Gen Z actors in Bollywood, few make as much noise as Sara Ali Khan. Her quirky *shayaris*, inspiring workout videos and picturesque travel diaries on Instagram, where she has 41.8 million followers (and growing), keep her in the headlines, sometimes more than her films. But one senses that the 27-year-old, five-films-old actor wants to turn the page and start a new chapter in her creative journey. No, she isn't giving up on her penchant for rhyme schemes; she's just looking to surprise audiences with her work. The whodunit, psychological thriller *Gaslight*, which releases on Disney+ Hotstar on March 31, signals the dawn of a more adventurous Sara. Talking to her reaffirms the belief that she is a tad wiser, more introspective and cognisant of her mistakes.

"I had started catering to different things," she says. "I was becoming louder, more attention-seeking and saying things that you wanted to hear rather than being myself, which is what people loved in the first place." The pandemic-necessitated break gave her time to ponder and realise that a course-correction was needed. *Kedarnath* (2018) and *Simmba* (2018) had got her off to a smooth start, but the hiccups came in *Love Aaj Kal* (2020) and Prime Video release *Coolie No. 1* (2020), with questions rising on her choices. Looking back on the professional lull, Khan says, "I was told they would work and I was stupid enough to believe that."

What changed? *Atrangi Re* (2021), her second straight direct-to-digital release, got her acting chops noticed. It was a much-needed fillip. Khan decided there'd be no more calculations; it was time for instinct to kick in. "One got hungrier to learn," she says, "The desire to do meatier films grew. It's the age to explore different kinds of cinema and make mistakes." Her attempts at reinvention include *Gaslight*, where she plays a wheelchair-bound woman who grows suspicious of her grandfather's absence only to be shut down and doubted. Also starring Vikrant Massey and Chitrangada Singh, it is a film where Khan, as the protagonist, has to do much of the heavy lifting.

Khan revels in that responsibility. "It has been a genuine desire of mine to do films where I don't have a genre that's going to restrict or bracket me," she says, "I am a very high-energy, bubbly person, so *Gaslight* is not something you would expect me to do. Second, it is not something I expected myself to do." That filmmaker Pavan Kirpalani [*Ragini MMS* (2011), *Phobia* (2016), *Bhoot Police* (2021)] came to her with a character whose mental faculties are questioned and whose movements are restricted was challenging. Says Khan, "I was raised by a single mother who has only given me love. I don't know what it is like to be in an environment where there's no trust. It is alien to me."

What helped was shooting the film at one go in Gujarat. The physical isolation and separation from home, says Khan, helped her sink deeper into Meesha's predicament. Rather than take the method approach, Khan's approach involved "understanding the emotional landscape of the character with empathy". "It's more exciting to use imagination than bog myself down mentally," she adds.

From Alfred Hitch-

Whether **Gaslight** will start a conversation in India about the concept itself remains to be seen, but Khan hopes it'll raise awareness

